explained in further detail later, but fundamentally it consisted of believing Russia – irrespective of who ruled it – to be a permanent rival for influence within southern Asia, and a threat to Britain's position in India. Indeed, this Great Game thinking tended to over-emphasise the danger of Russia to Britain's imperial interests and, after 1917, often judged Bolshevik foreign policy by that pursued by the tsarist government, thereby failing to formulate policies which would counter the potential for Bolshevism to take hold in South Asia. As pointed out above, southern Asia was where Britain and Russia had traditionally played out their rivalry and Anglo-Soviet relations were still largely defined by interaction in this region of the world. For Britain, the Bolshevik revolution had not constituted a great watershed, and for those of a Great Game mentality, policy towards South Asia and policy towards Russia were largely intertwined.

The legacy of the Great Game also meant that countries such as Persia and Afghanistan were seen by many in Britain only as pawns in the contest with Soviet Russia. The value of these two countries lay almost exclusively in their relation to Anglo-Russian rivalry and the security of India's borders, while their internal politics were generally ignored by Great Game thinkers. This focus on Russia as a threat and this view of Persia and Afghanistan as mere pawns resulted in a failure of some in the British government to recognise the rising strength of the pan-Islamic and nationalist movements taking hold of Asia in the post-war period. Those who did realise the seriousness of these movements would be largely ignored by the Great Game thinkers. Thus, while the Indian government would try to turn the attention of the Home government from Bolshevik Russia to nationalist Asia, London did not want to listen. Between 1918 and 1923, events would occur that would demonstrate the fallacy of this Great Game mentality, and force those who adhered to it to adjust their policies accordingly. Nonetheless, there is reason to believe that this fear of Russia was never really discarded by many British officials and that the modification of British policy that took place from 1921 was, in fact, simply a pragmatic change of tactics rather than a change of heart.

It is also often just as helpful to know what will not be included in a work as what it will include. This book does not purport to be a balanced exploration of Anglo-Russian rivalry in Asia in this period, but focuses